

THE VALUE OF AN INDIVIDUAL

TEXT: **Luke 15:1-7** *"Now the tax collectors and "sinners" were all gathering around to hear him. ²But the Pharisees and the teachers of the law muttered, "This man welcomes sinners and eats with them."³Then Jesus told them this parable: ⁴"Suppose one of you has a hundred sheep and loses one of them. Does he not leave the ninety-nine in the open country and go after the lost sheep until he finds it? ⁵And when he finds it, he joyfully puts it on his shoulders ⁶and goes home. Then he calls his friends and neighbors together and says, 'Rejoice with me; I have found my lost sheep.' ⁷I tell you that in the same way there will be more rejoicing in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who do not need to repent."*

INTRO: In our society everything is based on numbers; How much money a person has, how high or low the stock market is, the gross sales of a company, the population of a city, and on and on I could go!

This group mentality has even found it's way into the Church. We have judged ourselves on how big or small the crowd is! How many our group has in it! How large our staff is! How many people came to the evangelistic crusade! How many joined the Church! How many were baptised! How big the budget is! How many total dollars were given to missions! etc...

The question must be asked, is God at all interested in our facts and figures? Is he interested in our numbers? Yes! Several times in the Bible people were commanded by God to number various things! At other times they were instructed not to count! The woman counted her coins. the fisherman counted his fish. The king counted his troops. The farmer counted his crop. The builder counted the cost. God deemed numbers so important that he named a book in his Bible **"NUMBERS"**!

While all of these things are important, our scripture text makes us aware that nothing is more important than an **"INDIVIDUAL"**!!!

As a Church we must reach a point where the **"IMPORTANCE OF AN**

INDIVIDUAL” is non-negotiable! Do we have an easy come, easy go, attitude with regard to **“INDIVIDUALS”**?

Nowhere is the priority of the **“INDIVIDUAL”** more vivid than in the life and teachings of Christ himself!

I. SALVATION IS AN INDIVIDUAL EXPERIENCE!

A. 2 Peter 3:9 ***“The Lord is not slow in keeping his promise, as some understand slowness. He is patient with you, not wanting anyone to perish, but everyone to come to repentance.”***

Here Peter reveals that Jesus and the Father are motivated to see the salvation of 20 billion people who have called planet Earth their home! That huge crowd does not even include those who are not yet born!

B. Rev. 3:20 **“Here I am! I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in and eat with him, and he with me.”**

Here we are made aware that the incredible of salvation for every person will never exceed the rate of one **“INDIVIDUAL”** at a time!

C. The salvation of the **“INDIVIDUAL”** drove the entire redemptive plan, nothing else has ever taken priority!

Salvation is never a group experience! Salvation is for the **“INDIVIDUAL”**! If the whole world gets saved today, they will get saved **“ONE AT A TIME”**!!!

II. LOOK AT THE INDIVIDUAL NATURE OF GOD’S PLAN!

A. The **“INDIVIDUAL”** nature of God’s plan overwhelmed the psalmist David. **Psalm 8:3-4** **“When I consider your heavens, the work of your fingers, the moon and the stars, which you have set in place, what is man that you are mindful of him, the son of man that you care for him?”**

A survey of the entire Bible reveals that God always prioritizes the **“INDIVIDUAL”**!

B. From Melchisedec to Malachi, from Zidon to Zechariah, from Hilkiah to Haggai, from Zipporah to Zephaniah, from Hagar to Habakkuk, from

Noah to Nahum, from Miriam to Micah, from Jehosaphat to Jonah, from Obed to Obadiah, from Abraham to Amos, from Jochebed to Joel, from Hezekiah to Hosea, from Deborah to Daniel, from Enoch to Ezekiel, from Jacob to Jeremiah, from Isaac to Isaiah, God's love singled out each **"INDIVIDUAL"**!

C. Jesus' teaching communicates the centrality of the **"INDIVIDUAL"**, but his life and ministry made this truth even clearer;

- 1) Zacchaeus
- 2) The Samaritan woman
- 3) Legion
- 4) The thief on the cross

It is true that there is strength in numbers, **"ONE"** can put a hundred to flight but **"TWO"** can put ten thousand to flight!

It is also true that **"ONE"** is enough for every challenge, if empowered by God!

- 1) David and Goliath
- 2) Samson pulled down the house of the Philistines!
- 3) Shammah defended a pea patch
- 4) A little boys lunch

CONCLUSION: Notice our text, [Luke 15:1-7](#) *"Now the tax collectors and 'sinners' were all gathering around to hear him. ²But the Pharisees and the teachers of the law muttered, 'This man welcomes sinners and eats with them.'* ³*Then Jesus told them this parable:*

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There are three things here;

- 1) The shepherd who owns 100 sheep has lost one!
- 2) Notice the drastic measures to find one lone sheep! ***"He leaves 99 in the open country and searches until he finds the one lost sheep!"***

3) Notice the celebration! He puts it on his shoulders- He brings it home- He calls his friends and neighbors together and invites them to participate in the party!

The most astounding thing about all of this is the words of Jesus in verse 7, "I tell you that in the same way there will be more rejoicing in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who do not need to repent."

Can anyone determine the **"VALUE OF AN INDIVIDUAL"**?

As a Church we need to focus on the **"VALUE OF AN INDIVIDUAL!"**